Two-Way Checkback

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Two-Way Checkback is an extension of the Checkback Stayman convention. Playing regular Checkback, 2♣ asks partner for a 4-card major in these auctions:

Opener	Responder
1♣/♦	1♥/♠
1NT	2♣

Opener	Responder
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♣

Here 1NT shows 11-14 HCP if you employ a strong 1NT opening (15-17). Responder's 2♣ promises at least game-invitational values, or roughly 10+ points.

Two-Way Checkback, however, goes further by conventionalizing *both* the 2♣ and 2♦ rebids. The difference is that 2♣ is game-invitational, whereas 2♦ is game-forcing.

Responder's Rebid	**Meaning**
2♣	10 to a bad 12 points; artificial relay to 2D. May also be a weak signoff in diamonds (rare).
2♦	12+ points, artificial and game-forcing (by an unpassed hand only).

Thus the following sequences "check back" for a 4-card major as well as the ones above:

Opener	Responder
1♣/♦	1♥/♠
1NT	2♦

Opener	Responder
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♦

Checkback vs. New Minor Forcing

Two-Way Checkback is also referred to as Two-Way New Minor Forcing. The difference is that New Minor Forcing only applies if responder bids a “new” minor, like so:

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♣

Playing New Minor Forcing, 2♦ would be a natural signoff.

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥
1NT	2♦

Similarly, 2♣ would be a natural signoff here.

Two-Way Checkback, on the other hand, always assigns the same meanings to 2♣ and 2♦. It does not matter if opener’s first bid was clubs or diamonds.

The 2♣ Response

After responder bids 2♣, opener must bid 2♦. This is a departure from Checkback Stayman, which asks opener for a 4-card major. Responder then clarifies his hand as follows.

Opener	Responder
1X	1Y
1NT	2♣
2♦	?

Responder's Rebid Meaning

Pass	Weak signoff with 5+ diamonds.
New major	4-card suit, invitational. This takes priority over rebidding a 5-card major.
Rebid major	5+ card suit, invitational.
Jump rebid major	6+ card suit, invitational.

Examples

Opener	Responder
♠ Q J 4	♠ K 10 5 3
♥ A 10 8 7 2	♥ 9 6
♦ 10 9	♦ K Q 8 6 3 2
♣ A Q 3	♣ 5

Opener	Responder
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	Pass (3)

1. Relay to 2♦
2. Completing the relay
3. Signoff with diamonds

Opener	Responder
♠ Q 9 4	♠ K 10 6 2
♥ 10 9	♥ A K 8 5 3
♦ A 10 8 7 2	♦ 9 6
♣ A K 3	♣ 5 2

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	2♠ (3)
2NT	Pass

1. Relay to 2♦
2. Completing the relay
3. 4 spades with 10-12 points

Opener	Responder
♠ Q 10 4	♠ K J 8
♥ Q 9 2	♥ A K 10 5 3
♦ K 8 7 3 2	♦ 9 6
♣ A K	♣ 10 5 2

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	2♥ (3)
4♥ (4)	Pass

1. Relay to 2♦
2. Completing the relay
3. 5 hearts with 10-12 points
4. Bidding game with 3-card support and maximum strength

Opener	Responder
♠ Q J 6	♠ A 7 5
♥ 10 9	♥ K Q J 6 3 2
♦ A 10 8 7 2	♦ 9
♣ A K 3	♣ 5 2

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	3♥ (3)
4♥ (4)	Pass

1. Relay to 2♦
2. Completing the relay
3. 6-card suit with 10-12 points
4. Accepting the game invitation with a maximum

The 2♦ Response

After responder forces game by bidding 2♦, opener's rebids are in priority order below.

Opener	Responder
1X	1Y
1NT	2♦
?	

1. Showing a new 4-card major

Opener	Responder
♠ 10 9 2	♠ A Q 8 5 4
♥ A J 9 7	♥ K Q 6 2
♦ A 10 7 2	♦ K 6 5
♣ A 5	♣ 9

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♦ (1)
2♥ (2)	4♥ (3)
Pass	

1. Artificial game force
2. 4 hearts
3. To play, in keeping with the principle of fast arrival

Here the partnership lands in the 4-4 heart fit, with the hope of setting up spades to discard diamond losers.

2. Showing 3-card support

Opener	Responder
♠ Q 10 6	♠ A J 7 5 4
♥ A 10 7	♥ K J 6
♦ A 10 8 5 2	♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A 5	♣ K 9

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♦ (1)
2♠ (2)	4♠ (3)
Pass	

1. Artificial game force
2. 3 spades
3. Fast arrival

3. Bidding 2NT

2NT denies 3-card support as well as a 4-card major.

Opener	Responder
♠ Q J 10	♠ A 7 5
♥ 10 9	♥ K Q J 6 2
♦ A 10 8 7 2	♦ 9 5
♣ A Q 3	♣ K J 2

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥
1NT	2♦ (1)
2NT (2)	3NT
Pass	

1. Artificial game force
2. Unable to support hearts or bid spades

Pros and Cons

In short, what does Two-Way Checkback accomplish? A key benefit is the flexibility to distinguish weak, game-invitational, and game-forcing hands. Here is an everyday auction with many branches.

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♠
1NT	?

Hand A
♠ K 10 7 3 2
♥ K J 9 5
♦ 9
♣ 8 5 4

Hand A can bid 2♥ to show less than 10 points. Opener can pass or correct.

Hand B
♠ A Q 7 6 2
♥ K J 10 5
♦ 9
♣ 8 5 4

Hand B can bid 2♣ to show 10-12 points.

Hand C
♠ A Q 7 6 2
♥ A K 10 5
♦ 9
♣ 8 5 4

Hand C can bid 2♦ to show a good 12+ points.

Hand D
♠ A K J 6 2
♥ A K J 10 5
♦ 9
♣ K 4

Hand D can bid 3♥ as a natural slam try. Slightly weaker or less distributional hands would go through 2D instead.

In “Modern Constructive Bidding”, however, the late expert Marshall Miles was critical of Two-Way Checkback. Miles did not care for the loss of the "Stayman" meaning of the 2♣ puppet:

> The disadvantage of playing two-way Checkback is that opener’s forced 2♦ rebid over 2♣ doesn’t provide any distributional information. So far as locating a trump suit is concerned, it just wastes half a round of bidding.
>
> | Opener | Responder |
> |---|---|
> | 1♣ | 1♠ |
> | 1NT | 2♣ |
> | 2♦ | 2♠ |
>
> Does responder show 11 points with a good five-card suit? A longer suit with fewer points? A balanced or unbalanced hand? Some players try to solve this problem by rebidding two of responder’s major over 2♣ with three-card support rather than making an automatic 2♦ bid.
>
> This has been a rather long-winded discussion of the reasons I don’t like two-way Checkback. My own preference is for Eddie Kantar’s idea: always use 2♣ as Checkback.

See also

- Checkback Stayman
  A variation of the Stayman convention after opener rebids 1NT.
- Crowhurst
  A 2♣ checkback bid by responder, when playing a weak 1NT.
- Fourth-Suit Forcing
  An artificial, forcing bid after the partnership has already bid the other three suits naturally.
- New Minor Forcing
  An artificial forcing bid used when responder bids 1♥/♠ and hears a 1NT rebid by opener.
- Roudi
  A conventional 2♣ rebid by responder to check back for major suit support.